

Build Android Apps Using PhoneGap

With all the hubbub around Android, it's tempting to make an app yourself. But considerations like, "I don't know Java," or "I'm just a Web developer and haven't ever done app development," hold back a lot of us. Fear not; PhoneGap comes to the rescue. In this article, I will show you how to make a simple "Hello World" app for Android using PhoneGap. I will also give you a few tips along the way so that these Web apps behave natively the way any normal Android app would. (Yes! It's possible.)



When Android Inc. developed Android back in 2003, no one really took notice. Then Google acquired it in 2005. Still, not much happened. Six years later, in 2011, we've witnessed a flood of Android devices—not just phones, but tablets, music players, in-car entertainment and what-not; everyone wants to go the Android way. Even Arduino, the popular open source physical computing platform for hobbyists, has been roped into the club. Tomorrow it will be in all devices that can do something beyond telling the time; but who knows, maybe it will be in our clocks too. Android has gone where all open source software aspires to be: beating the cr*p out of proprietary platforms, and walking the talk: "Free is awesome."

About PhoneGap

Essentially, PhoneGap is a wrapper through which you can make a Web application using HTML/CSS, and build apps for not just Android, but all major platforms like Symbian,

Windows Phone, BlackBerry, Palm, etc. I have provided links and references at the end of this article, for your exploratory appetites.

Getting started

As for most development, you need to set up the environment. Here, we will use a GNU/Linux PC. I have used Fedora 15 as the distro of my choice, but if you use another, my instructions should work with little change.

You need OpenJDK or Oracle JDK installed, since Android apps are built with Java, and it's a dependency of the SDK as well. Most distributions come with OpenJDK. If it's not installed, use the Add/Remove Software panel (or Synaptic, in Ubuntu/Debian), search for, and install 'openjdk'.

Next, install Eclipse—a great IDE for development of any kind. In a terminal, run `sudo yum install eclipse`. If you have Ubuntu, use `sudo apt-get install eclipse`.